



ESOL Nexus professional development

**Positive strategies for managing
behaviour in ESOL prison classes**



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Introduction

ESOL Nexus professional development modules are intended to help teachers to develop in their role in a range of contexts. They have been written by expert practitioners and quality assured by a wider team. We hope that you will find this module useful. For other professional development opportunities, see

<http://esol.britishcouncil.org/professional-development>

This module is about managing behaviour in a positive way in ESOL classes in a prison environment and is suitable for teachers at any stage of their career.

It considers issues underlying poor behaviour in classes and gives practical strategies for managing disruptive learners. It focuses on the role of the teacher and how they can pre-empt negative behaviour by using positive behaviour management strategies. There are practical activities drawing on good practice and research as well as activities for reflection and action-planning.

Using this module

- While you can work through the module on your own and at your own pace, you will get greater benefits by working through it together with colleagues.
- If you are looking at the pdf on your computer you can type your reflections into the boxes provided, and save your progress for the next time you return to the module.
- There are links to videos embedded in the activities and suggested answers for activities at the end of the unit, as appropriate. There is also list with further reading related to the content.



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Understanding behaviours of ESOL learners in prison

This step will help you to answer the following questions

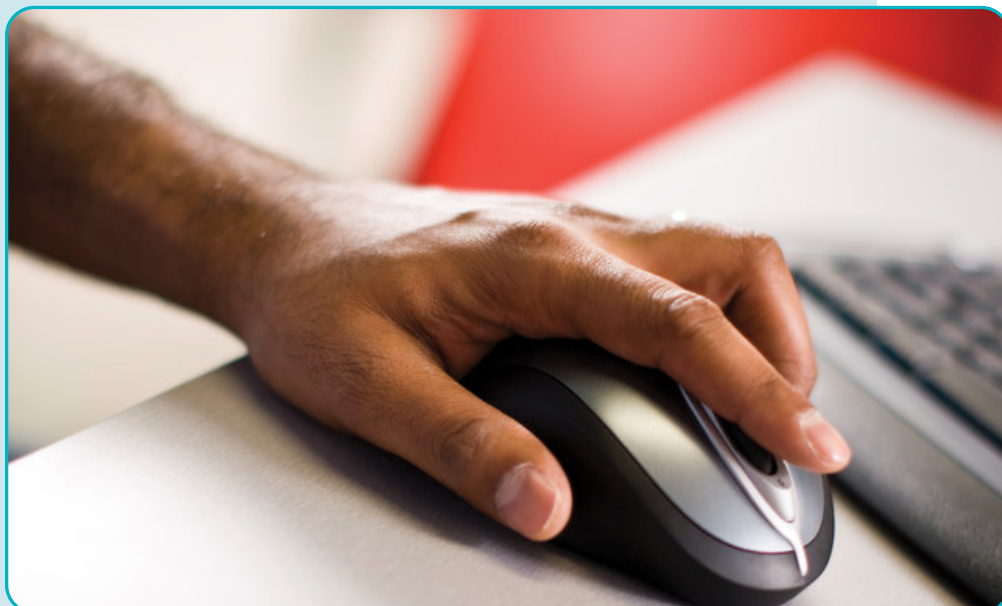
- What kinds of negative behaviours do learners in prison display?
- What are some of the causes of negative behaviour?
- How does the type of teacher I am affect my relationships with learners?

The pressures of prison life, the regime and culture are exacerbated for those who have a limited experience of English and who may be a long way from family and friend. ESOL prison learners extol encompass a wide diversity of languages and levels of English language skills, with the majority at a basic level.

While most of your ESOL learners will be eager to learn and participate in class the complexity of issues and stresses in relationships between learners in prison may result in negative behaviours.

This module introduces you to positive strategies that can help you to manage a range of behaviours and help you consider your own practice as a teacher.

Step 1



Assessing my current knowledge and understanding of positive behaviour management

Disruptive or non-compliant learners may be found in any group of ESOL learners but they are more likely to be present in a prison class. Positive behaviour management focuses on the methods we can adopt to promote effective learning through building and maintaining teaching environments where learners feel safe, valued and able to learn to the very best of their ability.

There are things you can change in your classroom, but you can do little about many aspects of prison life that affect teachers and you just have to work around them.

You need to be aware of skills you can develop yourself, and the support available to help you manage and grow positive behaviours in your classroom. This includes teamwork and consistency of protocols and rules across the education department, so learners are clear about what is and what is not acceptable. We will focus on what you can build on with your learners in your classroom.

Step 1a

Activity 1: Reflection on developing my skills in positive behaviour management

How do you learn about positive behaviour management in your prison classroom? How useful are these methods to you? Score them out of 10

How I learn about positive behaviour management	Score
I read books and articles	
I talk to other teachers in prison and ask advice	
I use observation reports of my teaching to help me reflect	
I go on courses or complete on line or 'face to face' training	
I discuss issues with my mentor or manager	
I use the prison education guides and learner agreements	
I watch other teachers	
I try new approaches and reflect on how they work	
I use experiences outside the classroom to help me	
I understand the policy on behaviour available from my education department	

Have a look at your scores.

- Which of the methods haven't you tried or considered yet?
- Would any of the learning methods you have not tried yet be useful to you?
- Who are the people that can help and support you?

It's important to have a cohesive approach to managing behaviours in a positive way. How and where could you discuss behaviour management in your workplace?

Write down three possible sources of help in your workplace.

1. 2. 3.

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

Activity 2: Reflecting on positive behaviour management in my workplace

Thinking about you, your education department and your learners, read the following statements and move the arrow between 1 and 10 to show how closely your practice matches the following statements.

I have a framework in place that sets out clear expectations for my learners



I describe clearly to my learners the behaviour I expect from them



I praise my learners for behaviour that supports learning



I positively encourage and help build good working relationships between learners



I share a clear and common framework for positive behaviour management with my colleagues



Study your responses on the (sliding) scale. Identify the areas where you need more support, practice or information. Refer to the reading list and support ideas at the back of this pack for further help and information.

Understanding my learners

Activity 3 Issues affecting behaviour

These extracts describe some of the challenges for learners in prison.

A significant number of prisoners suffer from a psychotic disorder. 14% of women and 7% of men serving prison sentences have a psychotic disorder; 23 and 14 times the level in the general population. The rate among the general public is about 4%.

26% of women and 16% of men said they had received treatment for a mental health problem in the year before custody.

Personality disorders are particularly prevalent among people in prison. 62% of male and 57% of female sentenced prisoners have a personality disorder.

49% of female and 23% of male prisoners in a Ministry of Justice study were assessed as suffering from anxiety and depression. 16% of the general UK population (12% of men and 19% of women) are estimated to be suffering from different types of anxiety and depression.

46% of women prisoners reported having attempted suicide at some point in their lives. This is more than twice the rate of male prisoners (21%) and higher than in the general UK population where 6% report having ever attempted suicide.

Adapted from the Prison Reform Trust (www.prisonreformtrust.org) Civitas 2010

There is a proven correlation between illiteracy, innumeracy and offending.

Before custody:

- 52% of male offenders and 71% of female offenders have no qualifications whatsoever.
- 48% of prisoners have literacy skills at or below level 1 and 65% have numeracy skills at or below level 1.
- More than one third of people in prison have a reading level below Level 1 and 75% for writing.(ii)
- Level 1 is what is expected of an eleven year old.(iii)
- Studies suggest that 23% of people who go into prison have very low IQs of less than 70

(www.civitas.org.uk/crime/factsheet-youthoffendingpdf)

Step 1b

Step 1b

What these shocking statistics show is that your learners may need all sorts of support apart from the help you give them with language. In fact, what we see in the classroom is just the tip of iceberg. It's what is hidden beneath that we need to explore.

From your knowledge of your learners, and from the information in the report extracts above, identify at least six of the behaviours you may encounter in an ESOL prison classroom that may result from, or be related to mental health issues and previous low attainment.

1.	4.
2.	5.
3.	6.

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

In addition many learners in prison are in a programme of drug or alcohol recovery which, in extreme cases, may affect their long or short term memory.

Drug use in prison

70% of offenders report drug misuse prior to prison
 51% report drug dependency
 35% admit injecting behaviour
 36% report heavy drinking: and
 16% are alcohol dependent'

Drugs: Breaking the Cycle – Home Affairs committee 2012

There may be emotional issues affecting the learners in your classroom.

The Bromley briefings note that many parents in prison do not get to see their children and the disruption to relationships and communication with families can be highly distressing.

www.bromleytrust.org.uk

Activity 4: The impact of learner culture

Learners' cultural background may also have an effect in a classroom. Read the profiles of the three learners from different cultures and consider:

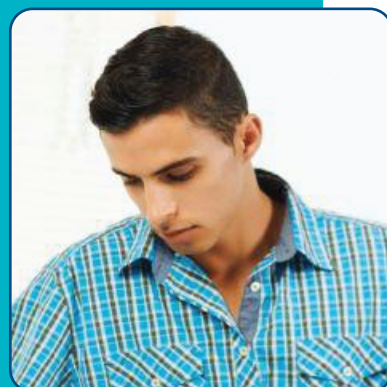
What management issues might they raise for you as a teacher and how might you deal with them?

[Click to see the suggested answers.](#)

Camlo has moved many times between towns and countries throughout his life and has not attended school on a regular basis. Formal education is not highly valued in his culture. As a result he finds it difficult to sit in one place for long periods and concentrate for long on tasks. He is easily distracted.

Wang Lui is used to being in large classes. He is not used to asking questions, even if he doesn't understand and is easily embarrassed when asked a question he can't answer. He has no experience of group or pair work and relies heavily on the teacher for direction.

For Adil it is important to have the right answers when the teacher asks, even if it means asking classmates for answers to questions he doesn't know. Having the right answers is the important thing, not how you got them and he is happy to give answers to other learners who ask him.



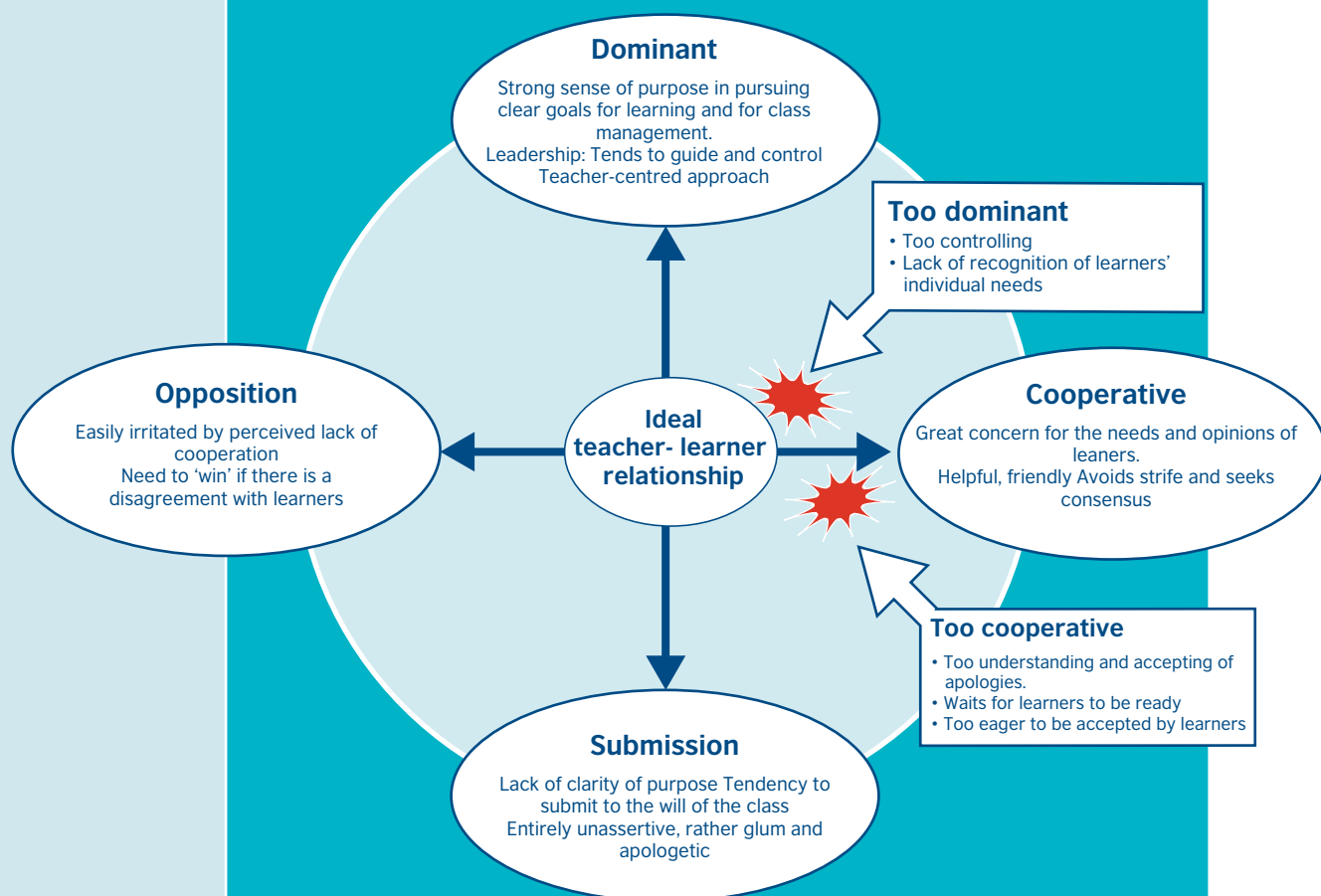
Step 1b

Assessing my teaching style in managing classroom behaviour.

Building effective teacher / learner relationships is vitally important in forming a good working environment in your classroom.

Activity 5:

Have a look at the model of teacher/learner relationships below¹. Where would you place yours with your learners?



Step 1c

¹Adapted from Geoff Petty Evidence Based Classroom Management and Discipline Chapter 26; accessed from www.geoffpetty.com November 2014

Step 1c

Research indicates that learners prefer a mix of dominant and cooperative teaching approaches. While it is important to be a leader in your classroom, it is always vital to cooperate and work with your learners. In a prison environment achieving the right mix can be difficult to achieve. Different classes may need different blends of dominant and cooperative approaches, depending on the individuals that make up the group and the way it develops. It's likely you will need to adapt your approach from class to class. Having a clear structure, procedures and approaches is very important in a prison environment, yet you will be working with vulnerable adults and so working with learners in a supportive and empathetic way is very important.

Think about your teacher / learner relationship and how you interact with your learners in the classroom. Write down 4 positive things about the way you can build good teacher / learner relationships and 4 things you do that you feel you would like to work on. Ask other teachers who have seen you teach to look at your list and share your perceptions of yourself.

Four strenghts I can build on	Four areas I need to work on
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.

Activity 6a

Look at the description of teacher behaviours in the diagram above.
How differently might a teacher from each style typically react to the following :

	Dominant	Co-operative	Submissive	Opposition
A learner is upset and keeps talking about their problem				
Learners are not concentrating or staying on task				
A learner refuses to do a task because they find it too difficult				

Step 1c

Suggested answers at the **end of the unit**.

Activity 6b

Now think how you might handle each situation and then decide which style best describes your actions.

1. A learner is very upset and keeps talking about their problem
2. Learners are not concentrating or staying on task
3. A learner refuses to do a task because they find it too difficult

- Where would you place yourself on the model?
- Is being in the centre the best place to be?

Add the areas you would like to work on to improve your positive behaviour management to your personal professional development portfolio.



Step 1c

Developing Strategies for managing negative behaviours

This step will help you to address the following questions:

- What kind of strategies can help to address different types of challenging behaviour?
- Who else can help me?
- What's my responsibility and what is not?

This extract summarises the challenges shared by teachers working in a prison. All the issues highlighted require particular strategies to encourage positive behaviour. As you read it note what you would do to address each challenge.

For sure you have to be a certain kind of person to work in a prison environment because you are called to be fair but firm, tolerant but not taken advantage of, supportive, caring, willing to go the extra mile, you need to be able to look at the whole person and not the criminality. You need to show respect and acceptance regardless as to why they are in prison. Not one day is the same and rarely is the day quiet or smooth as so many people have so many issues coming up for them.

Working in a prison education environment is nothing like working in an establishment outside. You are often dealing with emotional issues, health issues, anger issues, sometimes very bad attitudes, very low motivation and rock bottom confidence. Sometimes just the fact that the student turns up the next day is an achievement. You also need a great sense of humour as the depression that the men carry is huge ..., so a little encouragement to lighten their mood is vital. It is also important to be prepared for change, working with the class instead of being stiff and rigid complying to a lesson plan for example if there has been a death in the prison, many will be affected by it. Anything can kick off and you need to be able to manage incidents in order for you and your class to be safe. There are so many rules and regulations to follow working in a prison environment.'

Prison Educators against the odds. Rogers, L., Simonot, M. and Nartey, A. 2014 IoE / publication p 19

Step 2

Analysing styles of behaviour management strategies to use in the prison classroom

Activity 7: Rita's story

Rita teaches ESOL in a women's prison. She is encountering problems with behaviour in her class. Read her account of what is happening in her classroom.

I'm not new to teaching in prison but it never gets any easier. I work really hard to prepare lessons and interesting activities. There are only six in the class I've got now, but they really try it on. Zelma's the worst she always comes in on a high and is very loud. She's not rude, just loud; she takes ages to settle down and disrupts the others. I end up shouting at her, well, raising my voice, trying to get her to sit down and pay attention.

Jan never wants to do any work. She won't even look at me. I have to threaten to send her back to her cell before she'll do anything. She will sit and tap her pen on the desk or make silly noises to disturb the others and says she doesn't understand what I want her to do.

Najma is OK, she tries to settle the others but always says the work is too difficult and wants to take it back to her cell. I know her cell mate will do it for her, so what's the point? Suki sits next to Najma when she attends – she often has appointments and comes in half way through and that disturbs everyone as they want to find out what's been going on.

Meta is very withdrawn and rarely speaks. She won't join in with group activities. The others say that they don't want to work with her as she doesn't pull her weight. Zelma's said she's thick, which isn't true.

Sika is a chatterbox. She never stops talking and often swears, which I know is unacceptable. She is good at her work and joins in well but no one else can get a word in. She quickly completes her work and likes to finish early to sit and chat. She really winds me up.

They all have disagreements and start bickering – nothing serious, it just never stops! I've asked them to please stop – but they don't.

What can I do? I'm worried about asking colleagues for help and although my manager is supportive I don't want to tell her I'm having problems.

Step 2a

Step 2a

Examine Rita's actions as a teacher. Where would you put her on the teacher – learner relationship scale in activity 1C? Give your reasons.

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Here are some common elements that can result in creating negative behaviour from learners. Not all are caused by the learners. Sometimes a teacher's behaviour in the classroom can result in negative learner behaviour.

Identify the ones Rita encounters by choosing yes / no / or maybe.

Learners take charge by interrupting, shouting out answers, asking questions	yes	no	maybe
Teacher talks too quietly and can't be heard	yes	no	maybe
Excessive teacher led activity and not enough active learning	yes	no	maybe
Teacher helps individuals and doesn't see what's going on in the rest of the class	yes	no	maybe
Unclear instructions – learners not sure what to do	yes	no	maybe
Work set is undemanding – learners lose interest	yes	no	maybe
Teacher does not prepare well for the class	yes	no	maybe
Shouting: as the noise in the group rises, the teacher starts to shout – to be heard or to ask the learners to be quiet	yes	no	maybe
Teacher doesn't challenge inappropriate behaviour	yes	no	maybe
Teacher doesn't understand the cultural background of the learners	yes	no	maybe

Adopting positive behaviour management strategies

Activity 8

In the table below we have suggested some strategies to resolve the challenges Rita identified. Insert the issue from the list below beside the possible strategies, then add an idea of your own .

Behaviour challenge	What Rita could do	One of my ideas
	ensure a variety of short tasks	
	tactically ignore where possible and safe to do so	
	stay as calm as possible. breathe and give yourself a few seconds to respond	
	differentiate learning activities to ensure relevance	
	be clear about classroom behaviour expectations (or establish and agree ground rules for behaviour)	
	have games/ quizzes/ word searches or easy, fun activity ready to engage learners	
	give instructions in a quiet voice	
	use non verbal signals	

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

Step 2b

Activity 9

Watch the following videos which show an expert in school classroom behaviour talking about strategies for effective behaviour management. Although the context is different, ask yourself which of the strategies would still be relevant in an adult ESOL prison classroom. Fill in the table below after each video.



Watch video

Bill Rogers:

Establishing trust to enable classroom co-operation. (3.15 mins)



Watch video

Bill Rogers:

Dealing with distractions confidently. (5.34 mins)



Watch video

Bill Rogers:

Ensuring a settled and focused class. (4.29 mins)

	What are the main strategies outlined in the video?	What difference could these things make in your classroom?
1.		
2.		
3.		

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

Exploring different levels of negative behaviour

Activity 10

Study the list of behaviours below.

1. Which behaviours are low level behaviours to be addressed by you in the classroom?
2. Which behaviours are more serious and need to be addressed by you and your education manager?
3. Which behaviours need to be addressed by prison officers?

Divide them into 3 categories and add them in the spaces below

Pushing Clicking pen on and off Kicking Swearing Bullying
Physical abuse Arguing about everything Acting the clown Out of seat
Racial abuse Avoiding work Interrupting the teacher Name calling
Misuse of equipment Talking instead of listening when asked
Rocking on chair Telling lies Stealing

Me in my classroom	My manager and me	The wider prison service
.....		
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Step 2c

Activity 11

Think of three behaviour issues in your own classroom – which of these strategies have you tried to resolve it?

What else could you try from this list?

What will you use the next time a similar situation arises?

- Give clear calm instructions
- Make eye contact with learner
- Revise ground rules and expected behaviour
- Make your expectations for the lesson clear
- Making your expectations of learner behaviour clear
- Stay as calm as possible (at least on the exterior)
- Use humour where appropriate
- Describe what you want from the learner – don't plead!
- Ask learners to monitor their own classroom behaviour
- Make it clear not everything is open to negotiation – there are rules
- Give simple ultimatums – 'Najma, if you can't work alongside Zina without constantly chattering, I will have to ask one of you to move to the middle table'

Challenge	What I did	What else I could do

Planning for good behaviour: rules, routines and protocols

This step will help you to answer the following questions:

- What is my role in ensuring a well-behaved class?
- How can I create a stimulating environment which keeps learners engaged and motivated?
- How can I pre-empt poor behaviour?

Learners at Dewsbury College were asked to list the qualities of their ideal teacher. They identified the following¹:

- keeps order by being firm but not intimidating
- explains things clearly
- treats all learners fairly and equally
- is friendly and humorous
- gets to know learners' names / treats them as humans
- tries adventurous strategies / variety of techniques

Interestingly, when teachers were asked to create the same list, they did not mention keeping order. Mutual respect, clear boundaries and expectations are highly valued by learners, alongside teaching skills, variety and good humour.

In Step 1c, you considered the ideal and your own teacher-learner relationship.

In Step 2 you thought about having authority and using strategies to deal with challenging behaviours in class.

In Step 3 you will consider positive management techniques and your role

¹ Learning and Skills Development Agency (2007)
'What's your problem? Working with learners with challenging behaviour.'

in creating the foundation for a well-managed class. This firstly deals with your persona, attitude and expectations as a teacher, secondly looks at the ways you ensure good teaching, learning and engagement through the activities you prepare and finally deals with establishing a good classroom environment from induction onwards.



Step 3

The teacher's role in ensuring positive behaviour

Activity 12: Teacher interventions

How important do you think the interventions below are in helping teachers to create the foundation of good behaviour in class?

Rate each intervention strategy:

V very important - **Q** quite important - **NV** not very important.

1. promoting class ground rules		10. having well-planned lessons	
2. being consistent in use of ground rules		11. waiting for the class to be quiet before starting activities	
3. establishing class routines		12. only reprimanding when absolutely necessary	
4. recognising when learners are being attention seeking and not rewarding such behaviour		13. ensuring all learners are involved in questioning and any other activities	
5. monitoring the class well to keep learners on task		14. making consequences of bad behaviour clear	
6. giving simple, clear instructions		15. intervening early to keep order	
7. helping each learner clearly see and recognise their progress		16. planning activities which involve group and pair work	
8. having appropriate seating arrangements		17. having high expectations of learners and the class	
9. having clear turn-taking conventions		18. having a reward/ merit system for effort and hard work	

Adapted from Gribble (1993) in LSDA (2007)

Activity 13: The teacher persona

The learners in the Dewsbury survey said they wanted their teacher to be firm but not intimidating, friendly, humorous and treat all learners fairly. Look at the list below and pick out your strengths and any areas to work on.

- using eye contact to keep learners on task and pre-empt unwanted behaviour
- using body language which shows confidence
- giving classroom instructions politely, using please and thank you
- using a calm, confident and authoritative tone of voice
- using praise frequently
- valuing opinions and contributions of all learners
- never raising your voice
- diffusing difficult situations with humour
- taking a personal interest in learners
- lowering the voice to get learners' attention

Adapted from Gribble (1993) in LSDA (2007)

Activity 14a: Building rapport and staying positive

A good rapport is valued by both learners and teachers goes a long way towards maintaining positive behaviour in class. In the box below, add to the list of possible ways to build up a strengthen your rapport with learners.

- affirm their positive qualities regularly
- remember important things they've shared with you e.g. their birthdays, interests
- recognise progress / achievement

Activity 14b

However, learners' poor behaviour and attitude can challenge even our best efforts to maintain a positive relationship. Ask yourself this question:

How can I improve and maintain my positive attitude, raise my expectations and have a genuine interest in each individual?

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Step 3a

Activity 15: Helping learners be assertive not aggressive.

Keeping relationships positive in the classroom may also be helped by enabling learners to express themselves assertively rather than aggressively towards you or other learners. Aggressive behaviour blames others, threatens, insults and calls names. Assertive behaviour involves saying how you feel about the situation and stating clearly what you want to happen.

You could use some time in a lesson to help learners use assertive language by showing some examples of aggressive language and coming up with some ideas of how to say the same thing in an assertive way. Two examples are given. In the other boxes, think of some aggressive language you may hear in your own classes. Try to think of an assertive response you could teach your learners.

Aggressive response	Assertive response
I don't want to do this work. It's no good and boring. You don't give us easy work. You're not a good teacher.	This work is hard for me and I feel unhappy about it. Can you give me easier work?
Don't take my answers. Do your work. You're lazy and stupid.	Please don't take my answers. I don't like it. You must do your own work.

ESOL learners can appear rude due to not having the language skills to express politeness so this could fit very well with a language lesson about using polite language. The lesson would be a good opportunity to discuss a breakdown in communication and role play on how to respond assertively not aggressively.

Creating a stimulating learning environment

Activity 16: Engagement and motivation

Two of the qualities of an ideal teacher that learners identified related to their teaching – giving clear explanations, using adventurous strategies and a variety of techniques. These help increase engagement, enjoyment and participation and help learners focus on being productive rather than disruptive in class.

Motivation is also an important factor in the learning environment. Learners may not always come to class with a strong motivation to improve their English and may find the experience of learning de-motivating. Alan Rodgers (1996) wrote, ‘we forget that initial motivation to learn may be weak and die; alternatively it can be increased and directed into new channels.’¹ Seeing the relevance of what is being taught and having success are important factors in increasing intrinsic motivation to study.

Step 3b



¹ cited in Harmer (2007) The practice of English language teaching

Look at the list of strategies below and decide whether they would stimulate the learners' intrinsic motivation to learn and improve their English (M) or their engagement in and enjoyment of the lesson (E)

	M/E
1. Start every lesson with a memorable or fun icebreaker	
2. Give both written and oral instructions	
3. Explain lesson objectives and refer back to them at the end to show achievement	
4. Focus some lesson content on positive aspects of learner countries – role models, food, achievements, areas of natural beauty, as well as their interests	
5. Use some kind of game, quiz or fun activity every lesson	
6. Use a mix of pair and group work every lesson	
7. Include learner ideas in planning lesson topics and language	
8. Create opportunities for learners to discuss their ideas and opinions regularly	
9. Comment in every lesson on any positive progress made by individuals	
10. Differentiate tasks to suit different levels of learners	
11. Develop a simple reward or merit system – e.g. stickers, stamps, certificate	
12. Use the interactive whiteboard or PowerPoint to demonstrate language points, tasks and check answers, if available	
13. Use flashcard and cue card activities regularly	
14. Increase learner talking time	
15. Change activities frequently throughout the lesson to increase the pace	
16. Keep lessons relevant to prison situation and learner needs	
17. Keep learning active: moving round the classroom for some activities	
18. Set realistic goals with learners.	

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

Step 3b

Activity 17: Successful strategies from prison classrooms

Look at four ideas from teachers for creating a stimulating learning environment and motivating learners. Do you find them useful or impractical? How could you adapt them for your learners?

1. “I make wall posters in the class which highlight key points. I usually do a ‘Pronunciation Hit List’ and add to the list each lesson words they have particular problems with. It means I remember to practise with them regularly. We do a prepositions list which we keep updating class by class. Learners made a capital letter poster themselves.”

3. “I use games and quizzes often - a recap quiz to start or during the lesson. I tell the learners things I will test them on at the end. I use traditional formats like bingo and games with dice or I use ideas from teaching resource books and the internet. My learners really enjoy prizes. I don’t give points, they win toy pretend money or I take in pictures of prizes to win and hand them out at the end.”

2. “I like to use the learners as ‘teachers’. They like it when I say they are the teacher - they even get quite bossy! We do regular spelling practice so one of them is the ‘teacher’, gives the test and marks it then they swap over. If a learner has been absent, I ask the other learners to be the teacher and recap the key learning points. They also write tests for each other – gap fill questions or anagrams, for example, and give them to another learner to solve”

4. “I use questionnaires a lot. Learners have to ask three or four others the same questions – it gets everyone talking and they get to know each other better.”



Activity 18: Learning styles

Individuals respond better to some styles of activity than others so make sure you cater for the three main learning styles – auditory (the main stimulus is listening), visual (the main stimulus is visual) and kinaesthetic (the main stimulus is practical and hands-on).

Look again at the activity ideas suggested by the four teachers and decide which learning styles would be stimulated by the activities involved.

1.

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2.

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3.

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4.

.....

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

How do you try to cater for different learning styles in your lessons?

Step 3b

Starting as you mean to go on

‘One of the most useful strategies that staff can use is to negotiate ground rules of behaviour with the learners. In such a situation, staff and learners make their expectations explicit by agreeing openly what behaviours they regard as unacceptable.’ (NIACE, 2012)

Prisoners are bound by rules imposed by the regime and may welcome the chance to be involved in setting ground rules to create the best possible learning environment. Having a stake in the process, having their views valued and feeling they have some control in setting boundaries should support good behaviour.

Step 3c

Activity 19: Ground rules

In the space below, note how you could incorporate setting ground rules in a lesson classes in the areas listed 1-7 and think of any you could add.

1. interaction between learners
2. acceptable learner language
3. respecting others
4. equipment for class
5. time-keeping
6. absence
7. speaking out in class

Class Rules

Do

Do

Do

Do

Don't

Don't

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In our classes we:

Always:

.....

.....

Never:

.....

.....

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

Now consider these four questions:

- Who decides the ground rules in your class – you, the learners or both?
- How explicit are you about these rules?
- How consistent are you in applying these rules in your classes?
- How do you ensure learners' co-operation in implementing the rules?

For further reading on the benefits and implementations of ground rules see NIACE (2012) p 37-38

Activity 20: Induction

New class induction is a good time to focus on developing good relationships and a positive culture in the classroom. It's the time to establish ground rules and include activities to encourage social bonding and positive attitudes to each other.

Which of the activities below could you use or adapt for your new classes?

Activity 1: Get to know you: discuss as a class (or in smaller groups then feed back) what learners have in common – food preferences, likes, dislikes, hobbies etc. – and what is unique to each learner. Record the information on paper with a large circle drawn in the middle. Things in common are written in the circle and the unique elements are written in the space around the circle.

(Idea taken from <http://www.diversityanddialogue.org.uk/resources>)

Activity 2: Cultural awareness: give each learner a piece of paper and ask them to draw their national flag, and note their typical national food/ drink/ games/ sport/ hobbies, famous people and places. Before each learner presents details about their country, other learners should have the chance to say what they think they know about the country and be able to ask questions after the presentation.

Activity 3: Respecting others: write the word pairs listen/ speak, share/ take, rude/ polite on the board. Clarify meanings. Ask learners when it is good to speak and when it's good to listen to each other, if it's good to take or share with each other and what they think is polite behaviour and rude behaviour.

Activity 21: New learners in established classes

Classes may change frequently owing to prisoners being transferred to other prisons, released or new inmates joining at any time. It's important to make them feel part of the class and aware of the class rules and ethos.

Look at the induction areas below and decide which might be the best option for dealing with a new learner.

1. Explaining class ground rules:

- a) tell the learner the rules one to one
- b) ask the other learners to explain the ground rules
- c) give the new learner a hand out with them on

2. Getting to know other learners:

- a) ask the learners to introduce themselves
- b) do a get to know you activity
- c) ask the learner to introduce him/ herself to the class

3. Cultural awareness:

- a) do a cultural awareness activity from Activity 20
- b) ask the learner to tell everyone about their country
- c) teacher asks the class what they know and about the new learner's country.

[Click to see suggested answers](#)

Reflection

In this module you have considered how you can develop strategies for positive behaviour management, understand your learners more and create a stimulating learning environment. Now spend a short time reflecting on what you have learnt.

Stage 1: What?

Consider what you want to remember about:

- understanding the backgrounds of your learners
- building the teacher/ learner relationship
- strategies for managing negative behaviour
- positive behaviour management good practice
- creating a stimulating learning environment and motivating learners.
- planning for good behaviour from induction onwards

Stage 2: So what?

Reflect by considering your thoughts and feelings about the content in the module and making notes.

- How do you feel now about the way you normally manage behaviour in your classes?
- Have there been any changes in your thinking about how you interact with learners, the strategies you use and how you plan for good behaviour?

Stage 3: Now what?

How can you apply what you have learnt in this module to your own teaching context? Use these points to help make an action plan.

- Identify any further sources of help in continuing to improve your behaviour management, lesson planning and good classroom practice.
- Identify specific strategies and interventions to put into practice with specific classes and learners.
- Put at least one of the suggestions from above into practice in the next 2 weeks.

Suggested answers to activities

Activity 1

Discussion with your mentor, team meetings, CPD events, colleagues, staff focus groups, reading articles / research about behaviour management.

Activity 3: Possible behaviours:

Low self esteem	Difficulty Socialising and working with others
Lack of confidence	Withdrawn behaviour
Not understand acceptable classroom behaviour	Lack of social skills
Range of LLDD issues	Aggressive behaviour
Poor literacy levels	Effects of drug withdrawal programmes on personality
Dyslexia	Long / short term memory problems caused by drug and alcohol addiction
Depression	
Anxiety	

Activity 4

Camlo: may become disruptive if he is bored and restless and so distract others. He may not prioritise his own learning and as a result may make little tangible progress.

In response: Keep the lessons fast paced and varied with plenty of kinaesthetic activities and the chance to get up and move. Praise and encouragement can increase motivation when it's genuine feedback about any progress being made.

Wang Lui: it might be difficult to get him to answer questions in front of the whole class. He may often hang back in pair and group work and let others contribute first.

In response: include him in questioning but nominate others first. Try to ask him something he can answer correctly to build his confidence. To check if he has any questions, ask him one-to-one or ask all the learners one by one rather than directing a general question to the whole class. In time, learners who are unused to pair or group work usually come to value it and take part more readily as they feel more comfortable in the class.

Suggested answers to activities

Adil: it is difficult to judge whether a learner really understands and is making progress if it is unclear which work is their own and which is copied from others.

In response: make it clear to the class how important it is that you see their own work – right or wrong – so that you are able to help them improve. Stress that wrong answers are not a problem because it helps you know what to recap. Show learners you are aware of the issue and gently remind them to do their own work. Check understanding orally frequently.

Activity 6a

	Dominant	Co-operative	Submissive	Opposition
A learner is upset and keeps talking about their problem	Tells the learner to be quiet and deal with the problem outside the class	Allows a little time for the learner to 'get things off their chest' then continues with the class	Allows the class to become involved with the problem and focuses all attention on one learner	Tells the learner they have come to the class to learn and need to get on with their work
Learners are not concentrating or staying on task	Tells the learners they are a bad class and must get on with their work immediately or will be reported	Asks the class/ individuals how they are getting on: what's stopping them progressing?	Asks the class what other activity they would like to do as they find this one boring	Teacher gets angry with the class for not concentrating and raises their voice
A learner refuses to do a task because they find it too difficult	Tells the learner they were given instructions and must get on with the task	Asks what it is the learner is finding difficult and then support learning	Says 'Don't worry, I'll give you something different.'	Reminds the learner it was too difficult last week, as well. Asks why are they finding it difficult?

Suggested answers to activities

Activity 7

Learners take charge by interrupting, shouting out answers, asking questions	yes
Teacher talks too quietly and can't be heard	maybe
Excessive teacher led activity and not enough active learning	maybe
Teacher helps individuals and doesn't see what's going on in the rest of the class	maybe
Unclear instructions – learners not sure what to do	yes
Work set is undemanding – learners lose interest	maybe
Teacher does not prepare well for the class	no
Shouting: as the noise in the group rises, the teacher starts to shout – to be heard or to ask the learners to be quiet	yes
Teacher doesn't challenge inappropriate behaviour	no
Teacher doesn't understand the cultural background of the learners	maybe

Activity 8

Behaviour challenge	What Rita could do	One of my ideas
improve lesson beginnings	have games/ quizzes/ word searches or easy, fun activity	have a 'get it off your chest' session for the first 10 minutes of the class
support short concentration spans	ensure a variety of short tasks	use question / answer work in pairs / small groups
learners finding work too difficult	differentiate learning activities	look carefully and revisit initial assessment
attention seeking behaviour	tactically ignore where possible and safe to do so	give learner a choice – behaviour / consequence
low level disturbances like pen tapping	use non verbal signals	give your individual attention to their work
incessant chattering	give instructions in a quiet voice	change the activity
swearing	explain your expectations clearly	revisit ground rules
class disagreements and bickering	stay calm	reinforce good behaviour with praise

Suggested answers to activities

Activity 9

1. When starting to get to know new learners, deal with the lack of focus on work in a supportive, non-threatening way before dealing with the presenting behavioural issue calmly.
2. Apply ground rules consistently and give learners clear directed choices in response to a request to behave appropriately. Never get drawn into an argument and tactically ignore resulting incidental behaviour.
3. Use directional language rather than questions such as 'Can you...?' for settling the class. Keep the language positive and avoid using 'Don't..'. Use calm, clear, positive language.

Activity 10

Me in my classroom	My manager and me	The wider prison service
Rocking on chair Arguing about everything Talking instead of listening when asked Interrupting the teacher Acting the clown Out of chair Clicking pen on and off Mild pushing and shoving	Telling lies Misuse of equipment Swearing Refusal to do work (but may include anything from <i>Me in my classroom</i> depending on severity!)	Racial abuse Physical abuse Stealing Kicking Aggressive or violent behaviour

Activity 14b

You could find out about the learners backgrounds to help understand the reasons for their behaviour. Notice and praise any positive qualities. Also make sure you have a colleagues to support you when things get on top of you.

Suggested answers to activities

Activity 16

1. E	2. E	3. M	4. E	5. E	6. M
7. M	8. M	9. M	10. E	11. M	12. E
13. E	14. E	15. E	16. M	17. E	18. M

Activity 18

1. Visual/Kinaesthetic – wall posters, making a poster
2. Auditory/visual/kinaesthetic – spelling tests, creating games/activities
3. Kinaesthetic/auditory – games, listening and responding
4. Kinaesthetic/auditory – walking dictation

Activity 19 Examples

1. Be friendly and work together well in groups.
2. Be polite.
3. Take turns to speak.
4. Bring a pen, paper and previous class work every lesson.
5. Share classroom equipment with each other.
6. Come to class on time or give a reason for being late.
7. Tell your teacher if you cannot come to class or you have to leave early.
8. Help other learners.

Don't be rude.

Don't use bad language.

Don't interrupt.

The class could make a poster (possibly illustrated) of the rules for the classroom or a handout to be copied for each learner. You just use positive statements (do...) or use the lesson to teach the imperative, always/never and so on.

Suggested answers to activities

Activity 21

- 1b. This option re-establishes and reinforces the rules for the whole class again.
- 2b. Although this takes time and has to be different from other such activities done previously, it's the most interesting and non-threatening way for the new learner.
- 3a. Something which involves the whole class rather than singling out the new learner may be the most helpful.

Further reading and websites

Braggins, J. and Talbot, J. (2003) Time to Learn: Prisoners' Views on Prison Education. London: Prison Reform Trust.

Harmer, J (2007) The practice of English language teaching. (4th Ed)

Harlow. Natale, L, (2010) Factsheet - Education In Prisons

NIACE (2012) Managing challenging behaviour within skills provision for unemployed adults. http://www.niace.org.uk/sites/default/files/project-docs/managing-challenging-behaviour_web_final.pdf

Petty, G, (2009) Evidenced Based Teaching: a practical approach. Nelson

Thornes Rogers L, Simonot M and Nartey A, (2014) Prison Educators: professionalism against the odds Institute of Education/University and College Union

Prison Reform Trust (2014) Prison: the facts. Bromley Briefings Summer 2014 (www.prisonreformtrust.org.uk)

The Manchester College Exploratory Research: Staff perception of learner behaviour, behaviour management, the introduction of a 'Time-Out' room and the behaviour and educational experience of young people within the Learning & Skills Department at HMYOI Hindley.

Tissot ,C et al (2007) What's your problem? Working with learners with challenging behaviour. Learning and Skills Development Agency Available at: http://www.itslifejimbutnotasweknowit.org.uk/files/LSDA_WhatsyourProblem.pdf